

Teaching Portfolio

Levi Lowe

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I. Teaching Statement

“Anyone other than Levi?” I was the front-row student, nodding, hand up before the question was finished. At the time, I assumed the silence around me was a matter of preference: some people just don't like to talk. As an instructor, I now see that I was wrong. Participation is mostly a product of the room, the very thing I control as the instructor. So I design for it, and my classrooms are lively.

When I come into class, I am talking to my students before the session starts. Sometimes I give them riddles or tell them fun facts. I always ask them how they are. When class starts, I make a tradition out of checking in administratively as well. *Is anything confusing or unclear about what is expected of you?* When we launch into content, I often conduct discussions in what my favorite undergraduate professor would call “Socratic circles.” I rearrange the chairs into two distinct circles—one smaller circle inside a larger circle. The inner circle has a guided discussion about the topic of the day for some allotted amount of time (often between 10 and 20 minutes). Meanwhile, the outer circle observes and analyzes the discussion—not focusing on their opinion of the content nor who they agree with. Instead, they analyze *how the discussion went*. Did it flow? Did someone dominate? Was it a debate or did everyone agree? What would you like to see repeated when it's your turn? What would you avoid? Why? When the inner circle's discussion ends, the outer circle reports their analysis *out loud* while the inner circle listens. Then the circles switch and the process repeats. I have never guided nor participated in a more successful discussion-based in-class philosophy exercise. I appreciate that the inner circle gets the room to speak while the attention on them encourages considerate behavior. Then the outer circle learns to see a discussion *as a discussion* rather than waiting to add one's own opinion on the matter. They learn to listen to a structure. Students report loving this exercise and my smaller ethics courses adopted it as a classroom standard.

If half the work of fostering a lively classroom is in curating the atmosphere, the other half is two distinct syllabus mechanisms. Firstly, I define participation explicitly and stay true to it: engaged contribution in a stated number of sessions, explained and posted on the first day of class, with a record kept of who speaks each session. Second, my “keyword discussions” give students a set of named roles to discuss from, roles such as: Excavator, who surfaces an unstated premise; Contrarian, who tests the argument; Complexifier, who troubles a framed binary. Along with five others. Students choose a role for each post, and by the end of the semester every student must have performed all eight. The roles give students with strong opinions somewhere to put them, and give students with no settled view a legitimate way into the discussion. Figuring out exactly how to set up a discussion during class, having these roles in mind, has definitely required experimentation. I once tried implementing a chess-style timer for allotting time to speak, but it just made the distribution of engagement much more apparent while offering no solution. So instead I focused on being a grounding facilitator of conversation, and it worked much better.

I build assessment on the same principle as I define participation: make the standard explicit, then let students choose how to meet it. My ethics courses run this way, for example. The final exam opens on the first day of the semester and is tiered: Level 1 identifies the ethical theories we cover, Level 2 draws out the practical obligations each theory entails, Level 3 applies a theory to a case we studied. In my writing-intensive courses, the term paper is scaffolded: two staged "prospective ideas," the first drawn from students' own entering interests and the second from course material, then a paper-writing workshop, then the paper, with a final-exam alternative for students the essay format does not serve.

My classes operate under the guiding notion that philosophy rewards textual and argumentative precision: reading closely, writing exactly, following an argument where it actually goes. But that is just what it takes to get the degree, and has almost nothing to do with how to teach it. Knowing something and getting a room full of undergraduates to care about it are painfully different skills, and the gap between them has grown enormous now that a language model will produce a competent paragraph on basically anything I teach. What a philosophy classroom still offers that nothing else does is live, face-to-face, unscripted discussion between people. That, too, I can teach. I always keep my own commitments out of the room. What I enforce instead is at minimum an argumentative standard: state the strongest version of the position you are arguing against, charitably enough that someone who holds it would recognize herself in it. That one rule has set the tone of entire discussions and is in fact the one thing I most want students to carry out with them, even if they never take another philosophy course again.

II. Evidence of Teaching Effectiveness

A. Representative Student Comments

PHIL 3350: History and Philosophy of Science

Enrollment: 25; Response: 20

“Levi is one of the **clearest instructors I have had in my education experience**. He is also emphatically dedicated to teaching and his dedication is extremely clear to us. **We students in his class feel deeply heard and considered**. Levi is also dedicated to education and **clearly teaches** the course material. Levi deserves many awards and **sets a new precedent for the future of academia**. He is kind and still an extremely clear educator. One of my favorite things about Levi is that he is **unafraid to say when someone is wrong but he always helps the student reach a more acute understanding**.” (Spring 2025)

“Levi is an **exemplary instructor** that **sets a new standard for the future of academia**. His teaching style **perfectly intertwines humor and rigor**. He creates a **welcoming class environment** which allows for the facilitation of **fruitful discussion**. **I think any student, regardless of field, would benefit from taking his classes**.” (Spring 2025)

“Levi is an amazing Instructor. His grading is relatively fast. He has a **very clear and strong passion** for both the topic and the people in his class. He keeps it lighthearted and fun, and **has no problem really breaking down topics to help your understanding**. He definitely is supportive of you and wants to see you succeed. His standards are well set and understood. He **genuinely is one of the best of riding the line of being understanding but not too lenient, structured but not overly strict**.” (Spring 2025)

“**Extraordinarily engaging person. Wish he taught all of my classes**.” (Spring 2025)

“I think that **Levi is one of the best course instructors I've ever had**. You could tell throughout the whole class that he **actually cared about the topic** and wanted to teach us it.” (Spring 2025)

“Excellent instructor and **made the class exciting to attend**. Levi had a lot of **energy and passion** for the class and his students, and had **no problem keeping class engaging** no matter the topic that was being discussed. **One of the better instructors I have had** the opportunity to learn from over the course of my college career.” (Spring 2025)

PHIL 3350: History and Philosophy of Science

Enrollment: 25; Response: 10

“Levi is such a **good instructor. He makes sure everyone participates** and understands the material. He is clear on his expectations and willing to help you fully understand course material if you're struggling. **His teaching style is fun and enjoyable!**” (Fall 2024)

“Levi is such a **great instructor**. He was patient and **made sure to include everyone in discussions**. He has a very charismatic personality and I thoroughly enjoyed learning from him.” (Fall 2024)

“**One of my favorite instructors**. He is **passionate** about what he teaches, is willing to help each student in whatever way is best, and has a **great ability to explain difficult subjects** in a way to help everyone understand no matter their level of understanding.” (Fall 2024)

PHIL 2050: Ethics and Values

Enrollment: 19; Response 9

“The instructor’s **enthusiasm** for the subject bled over to our class and **encouraged questions** and deeper understanding of the subject.” (Spring 2026)

“I thought all of the assigned **readings were really interesting and applicable** to what we were learning.” (Spring 2026)

PHIL 2050: Ethics and Values

Enrollment: 15; Response 10

“Levi Lowe was **very good at keeping conversations in class on track but also allowing us to explore the ideas** without only being lectured. He also was very good at **keeping neutral by not having the goal to tell us his opinion** but to inform us of the reading or the specific ethical theory we were talking about.” (Spring 2026)

“Levi had a **phenomenal attitude towards the class** every time that I attended his lectures. At least, I expected lectures with the occasional breakout group; however, **every class was very involved and engaging. I've never seen a class where everyone engages in the conversation willingly**. The weekly assignments also challenged me to respond to topics in ways that I normally wouldn't, expanding my depth of understanding as I battled with each perspective. Also, **it helps when a professor is funny. That's what probably helped me the most**” (Spring 2026)

PHIL 1001: Intro: Ethical Dilemmas

Enrollment: 48; Response: 28

“He was **energetic and made me excited about going to class**” (Fall 2025)

“He made class **so fun, and lively**. He allowed us to express how we felt while allowing us to understand how we truly felt about ethical theories and dilemmas. He did a great job.” (Fall 2025)

“He was **so engaging and fun to listen to in class!** Definitely brought an inviting energy and made it exciting to learn. **Super passionate** about this topic, and you can tell by the way he teaches.” (Fall 2025)

“**Great instructor, kind, communicative, very engaging**” (Fall 2025)

“Levi was good at getting people interested in the topics of discussion since you could tell he was **very passionate about it**. I also liked how **he treated us all like respectable philosophers**, eg. asking follow-up questions and trying to understand our thought processes.” (Fall 2025)

“He **helped me to learn how to think more distinctly**. I learned how not to be so broad and how to explain things effectively.” (Fall 2025)

B. Summary of Quantitative Evaluations

For the sake of coherence, I have summarized data only from in-person classes at the University of Utah for which I was the primary or co-instructor (58 responses total):

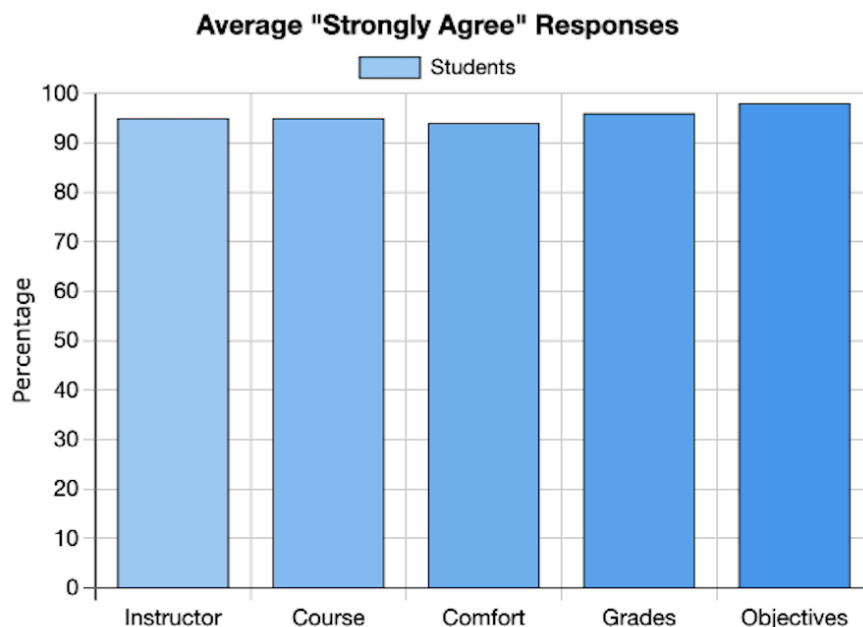
1. PHIL 3350 History and Philosophy of Science Fall 2024 (10 responses)
2. PHIL 3350 History and Philosophy of Science Spring 2025 (20 responses)
3. PHIL 1001 Intro: Ethical Dilemmas (28 responses)

Students were asked if they agree with various statements, but I have only included the five that speak directly to my teaching abilities:

1. I would recommend this instructor. (Instructor)
2. I would recommend this course. (Course)
3. I felt comfortable asking questions and openly expressing and discussing my views in this course. (Comfort)
4. I understood how my grades were determined in this course. (Grades)
5. Was it clear what you were expected to learn in this class? (Objectives)

Possible answers were “Strongly Agree,” “Somewhat Agree,” “Neither Agree nor Disagree,” “Somewhat Disagree,” and “Strongly Disagree.” This was true except for the final question, whose options were either “Yes” or “No.”

The chart reflects the average percentages of “Strongly agree” responses.



C. Course Observation Highlights

Below are two highlights from an in-person course evaluation conducted by a member of the Utah Valley University philosophy faculty during the Spring of 2026:

“His own obvious enjoyment of the discipline is contagious, and the spirited conversation carried over into the class session without interruption. Of the sixteen students in attendance throughout the class, I noted that thirteen spoke, and that the quieter students or those on laptops and tablets were actively following the conversation and taking notes.” (Reynolds 2026)

“From this class session, I got the impression that **Levi is a gifted philosophy instructor with a strong sense for tailoring material to students’ level of understanding**. He is most effective in discussion, where **students are eager to share in the joy he obviously takes from exploring ideas** in an open-ended way. In the more lecture-oriented portions of the class, **Levi conveyed the information clearly and effectively**, using the whiteboard to illustrate important points. Students clearly got a lot out of the theories covered, and enjoyed applying them and testing their limits, making this in some respects **a model of a good philosophy class**.” (Reynolds 2026)

III. Sample Syllabi

A. PHIL 3350: History and Philosophy of Science

Spring Semester

Course Description

PHIL 3350-001 fulfills an Upper Division Communication/Writing (CW) credit. This course—History and Philosophy of Science—covers theories about the aims and methods of science over time. That is, students will learn about the historical development of science. Using examples from the history of science, students will uncover different views of science. Topics include the relations between the sciences, between science and logic, and between science and religion.

Course Outcomes and Objectives

Investigations of the world have long circled around the same questions, such as: What is causation? What is evidence? How should science be demarcated from other forms of inquiry? That being said, the standards for what count as good answers to such questions have changed. We will begin by looking at different scientific conflicts in order to understand what has, historically, been considered as the right way to discover the truth about the natural world. To that end, from the scientific revolution, through logical positivism and Darwinian evolution, students in this class will interrogate key moments in the history of science by investigating the work of figures such as Aristotle, Galileo, and Darwin. These primary texts will be considered using methods modeled by philosophers of science and applied to cases in the history of science. We will investigate scientific paradigm shifts, what constitutes a scientific theory, scientific disagreements and advances, and pitfalls. Students will also learn basic deductive logic and contemporary philosophy of well-being.

Course Requirements

- 12.5%: Prospective Idea 1
- 12.5%: Prospective Idea 2
- 20%: Module Quizzes
- 25%: Weekly Discussion Posts
- 30%: Term Paper / Final Exam

Attendance and Participation

Show up on time and ready to engage. Students are allowed one free, unjustified, absence. Each absence after that will cost 1.5 percentage points from the final grade. Students will also be expected to contribute to in-class discussions. The discussions we have in class will: 1) prompt students to apply the concepts discussed in the previous classes, and 2) encourage them to remember what their fellow classmates said. **Full points on this criteria will be awarded to those who talk, in an engaged way, in at least 13 classes (ignoring workshop days).** Points will be reduced based on the number of classes with missed engagement out of the 13 required.

Module Quizzes

Each module will be about three weeks long. At the end of each module, there will be a 7-10 question quiz (short answer and multiple choice) regarding the information in the module. There will be no retakes. The quiz with the lowest grade will be omitted.

Weekly Discussion Posts

Along with a summary of the material, discussion will be based on the discussion questions you post each week. Questions will be graded on a scale of 1 (more effort needed) to 2 (fine job) to 3 (great work) to 4 (truly impressive). Questions covering matters of fact (such as the clarification of a concept, the identity of a historical player, etc.) will in most cases be graded lower than those addressing matters of interpretation (such as a criticism of an argument, an inquiry into the relation of material covered to other course material, etc.). Expected length: 100 - 150 words. These are due by 9pm on the day before our class at the beginning of each week. There will be 13 weekly assignments, starting on Week 2 and ending on Week 14. Each student may choose to ignore one weekly assignment for free. Each one missing or incomplete after that will cost 1.5 percentage points of the Weekly Assignments grade.

Prospective Ideas

Students will be asked to undergo the beginning stages of writing a paper—twice. When submitting a “prospective idea” in its gradable form, it will not be a full paper, but rather the idea of a full paper in the form of a developed outline or rough draft. The first prospective idea will mainly draw on one’s intuitive interests as one enters the class; it will be due September 29th. The second prospective idea will draw more majorly on the material we cover in class, due on November 10th. It may be inspired by one’s first prospective idea, but students are encouraged to conjure new ideas as well.

Term Paper

The term paper is the main product of this class. The final paper must draw on one of the two prospective ideas, and be ~3500 words. While the students are expected to present their term

papers, they will not be graded on this presentation further than the “participation” grade. The term paper will be due on Sunday, December 8th.

Students will have the option of taking a final exam, rather than submitting a final paper. The exam will consist of written responses to concept identification questions and essay prompts. If students fail to submit at least one prospective idea, they default to taking the final exam.

Grading Scale

A+ = 100-97	C+ = 79-77
A = 96-93	C = 76-73
A- = 92-90	C- = 72-70
B+ = 89-87	D+ = 69-67
B = 86-83	D = 66-63
B- = 82-80	D- = 62-60
	F = 59-0

University Policies

Americans With Disabilities Act (ADA)

The University of Utah seeks to provide equal access to its programs, services, and activities for people with disabilities.

All written information in this course can be made available in an alternative format with prior notification to the Center for Disability & Access (CDA). CDA will work with you and the instructor to make arrangements for accommodations. Prior notice is appreciated. To read the full accommodations policy for the University of Utah, please see Section Q of the Instruction & Evaluation regulations.

In compliance with ADA requirements, some students may need to record course content. Any recordings of course content are for personal use only, should not be shared, and should never be made publicly available. In addition, recordings must be destroyed at the conclusion of the course.

If you will need accommodations in this class, or for more information about what support they provide, contact:

Center for Disability & Access

801-581-5020
disability.utah.edu
65 Student Services Building
201 S 1460 E
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

Safety at the U

The University of Utah values the safety of all campus community members. You will receive important emergency alerts and safety messages regarding campus safety via text message. For more safety information and to view available training resources, including helpful videos, visit safeu.utah.edu.

To report suspicious activity or to request a courtesy escort, contact:

Campus Police & Department of Public Safety

801-585-COPS (801-585-2677)
dps.utah.edu
1735 E. S. Campus Dr.
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

Addressing Sexual Misconduct

Title IX makes it clear that violence and harassment based on sex and gender (which includes sexual orientation and gender identity/expression) is a civil rights offense subject to the same kinds of accountability and the same kinds of support applied to offenses against other protected categories such as race, national origin, color, religion, age, status as a person with a disability, veteran's status, or genetic information.

If you or someone you know has been harassed or assaulted, you are encouraged to report it to university officials:

Title IX Coordinator & Office of Equal Opportunity and Affirmative Action

801-581-8365
oeo.utah.edu
135 Park Building

201 Presidents' Cir.
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

Office of the Dean of Students

801-581-7066
deanofstudents.utah.edu
270 Union Building
200 S. Central Campus Dr.
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

To file a police report, contact:

Campus Police & Department of Public Safety

801-585-COPS (801-585-2677)
dps.utah.edu
1735 E. S. Campus Dr.
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

If you do not feel comfortable reporting to authorities, the U's Victim-Survivor Advocates provide free, confidential, and trauma-informed support services to students, faculty, and staff who have experienced interpersonal violence.

To privately explore options and resources available to you with an advocate, contact:

Center for Campus Wellness

801-581-7776
wellness.utah.edu
350 Student Services Building
201 S. 1460 E.
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

Academic Misconduct

It is expected that students comply with University of Utah policies regarding academic honesty, including but not limited to refraining from cheating, plagiarizing, misrepresenting one's work, and/or inappropriately collaborating. This includes the use of generative artificial intelligence (AI) tools without citation, documentation, or authorization. Students are expected to adhere to the prescribed professional and ethical standards of the profession/discipline for which they are

preparing. Any student who engages in academic dishonesty or who violates the professional and ethical standards for their profession/discipline may be subject to academic sanctions as per the University of Utah's Student Code: Policy 6-410: Student Academic Performance, Academic Conduct, and Professional and Ethical Conduct.

Plagiarism and cheating are serious offenses and may be punished by failure on an individual assignment, and/or failure in the course. Academic misconduct, according to the University of Utah Student Code:

"...Includes, but is not limited to, cheating, misrepresenting one's work, inappropriately collaborating, plagiarism, and fabrication or falsification of information...It also includes facilitating academic misconduct by intentionally helping or attempting to help another to commit an act of academic misconduct."

For details on plagiarism and other important course conduct issues, see the U's Code of Student Rights and Responsibilities.

Preliminary Course Schedule

Module 1: Some History of Science: What is it, and where does it come from?

January 6th - January 24th

Week 1: Introduction

- *January 6th*
 - Read:
 - Syllabus
- *January 8th and 10th*
 - Read
 - Godfrey-Smith, P. (2003), "Introduction" (1.1-1.4) from *Theory and Reality: An Introduction to the Philosophy of Science*
 - Aristotle's Four Causes Passage

Week 2: Galileo and the Scientific Revolution

- *January 13th - 17th*
 - Read:
 - "Galileo" from Matthews, M. (1989) from *The Scientific Background to Modern Philosophy*
 - Check out these videos!
 - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=frZ9dN_ATew
 - <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9BQKe9HT1OE>

Review: Prospectus 1 Assignment

Week 3: Darwin and a Revolution in Biology

- *January 20th*
 - HOLIDAY: MLK Jr. Day
- *January 22nd*
 - Read:
 - Sober, E. (2000), Chapter 2: “Creationism” in *Philosophy of Biology* (pp. 27-57)
- *January 24th*
 - Read: Excerpt from Darwin, “Tangled Bank”

Module 2: 20th Century Philosophy of Science

January 27 - February 10th

Week 4: Logical Positivism

- *January 27th*
 - Read:
 - Hempel, C. (1966) “Laws and their Role in Scientific Explanation” (pp. 47-69)
- *January 29th*
 - Cartwright, N (1980) “The Truth Doesn’t Explain Much” (pp. 159-163).
- *January 31st*
 - No in-person class.
 - Optional Reading:
 - Downes, S. (1997), “Logical Positivism/Logical Empiricism” (pp. 218-224).
 - **Write on the discussion board: one post plus one response.**

Week 5: Falsification

- *February 3rd - 7th*
 - Read:
 - Popper, K. (1963) Chapter 1: “Science: Conjectures and Refutations” (pp. 1-49)

Week 6: Workshop

- *February 10th*
 - *Paper-writing workshop*
- *February 12 - 14th*
 - TBD

Prospectus 1 is due by 11:59pm, Sunday, February 16th.

Module 3: Script Flips

February 17th - March 7th

Week 7: What is the actual problem with induction?

- *February 17th*
 - HOLIDAY: President's Day
- *February 19th*
 - Read:
 - Okasha 2001: What Did Hume Really Show About Induction?
- *February 21st*
 - No in-person class.
 - Start reading:
 - Kuhn 1962: Structure of Scientific Revolutions—Ch. 9
 - **Write on the discussion board: one post plus one response.**

Week 8: Paradigm Shifts

- *February 24th*
 - Read:
 - Kuhn 1962: Structure of Scientific Revolutions—Ch. 9
- *February 26th*
 - Read:
 - Lakatos: Falsification and the Methodology of Scientific Research Programmes
- *February 28th*
 - ...continued

Week 9: Human Nature?

- *March 3rd*
 - Read:
 - Hull 1986: On Human Nature
- *March 5th*
 - Read
 - Washington 2016: Culturally Unbound
- *March 7th*
 - Read
 - Amundson (2000): Against Normal Function

Week 10: SPRING BREAK***March 9 -16th*****Module 4: Philosophy of Self-Control****March 17 - April 4th***Week 11: Internal Values*

- *March 17th*
 - Read:
 - *Berkman et al 2017, Self-Control as Value-Based Choice*
- *March 19th*
 - Read:
 - *Washington 2018, Contextualism as a Solution to Paternalism in Psychiatric Practice*
- *March 21st*
 - Optional Reading:
 - *Kuhn 1962: Structure of Scientific Revolutions—Ch. 10*
 - Continue from previous two classes

Week 12: Internal Unreliability

- *March 24st*
 - Read:
 - Read: *Saunders et al. 2018, Reported Self-control is not Meaningfully Associated with Inhibition-related Executive Function: A Bayesian Analysis; feel free to ignore the methods section*
- *March 26th*
 - Read:
 - Read: *Schwitzgebel 2008, The Unreliability of Naive Introspection; read at least 10 pages*
- *March 28th*
 - Read:
 - *Robinson and Adinoff 2016, The Classification of Substance Use Disorders: Historical, Contextual, and Conceptual Considerations. Pages 8 - 18*

Week 13: Modern Views of Addiction

- *March 31st*
 - Read:

- *Sripada 2021*, Impaired control in addiction involves cognitive distortions and unreliable self-control, not compulsive desires and overwhelmed self-control
- *April 2nd*
 - Read:
 - *Leshner 1997*, Addiction is a Brain Disease, and It Matters
 - *Pickard 2021*, Is addiction a brain disease? A plea for agnosticism and heterogeneity
- *April 4th*
 - No in-person class.
 - Write on the discussion board. One post plus one response.

Prospectus 2 is due by 11:59pm, Sunday, April 6th.

Last Two Weeks

November April 7th - April 21

- Presenting Papers

Term Paper is due by 11:59pm, Sunday, April 27th.

Grades Due: Monday May 12th

B. PHIL 2050: Ethics and Values

Spring Semester

Course Description

The implementation of ethics and values scaffold much of our world. In this course, students will learn how to identify and analyze ethical dilemmas by examining real-life case studies. They will learn about different ethical frameworks in which to analyze approaches to these dilemmas. We will cover ethical theories such as consequentialism, deontology, and virtue ethics, and areas of application in bioethics, law, animal ethics, and personal identity.

Course Outcomes and Objectives

Over the course of the semester, students will:

- Consider recent ethical issues of concern to medical practitioners and researchers
- Become familiar with major theories of moral philosophy, and the standard principles of bioethics
- Articulate and defend an interpretation of an ethical dilemma using one of the primary moral theories
- Use concepts from ethics & philosophy to analyze the dilemma
- Engage in constructive discussion with others
- Apply philosophical thinking to ethical dilemmas in your personal and professional life
- Strengthen critical thinking and reading comprehension skills
- Extract subtle points from complicated readings, and use these in the construction of their own arguments.

Agenda

For the first few weeks, we will focus on the ethical foundations setting the stage for the ethical dilemmas we will discuss. Then, for the remainder of the semester, we will discuss the ethical dilemmas themselves. There will be at least one reading each week to help you better apply the concepts we discuss. The topics covered in this course will be visible on the Canvas homepage as separate modules corresponding to weeks of the course. The reading material for every week will be accessible throughout the semester. All materials will be available under their respective modules.

Grading Rubric:

Overall Grade: Earning 100% in the three primary categories (In-Class Participation, Online Discussion, & Final Exam) will earn you a 'B' for the class. To earn a 'B+', demonstrate mastery of the three primary categories and one advanced assignment. To earn an 'A', demonstrate mastery of the three primary categories and two advanced assignments. NOTE: You must pass all three primary components to pass this course, and pass the advanced assignments to improve your grade. Failing a primary component may lead to a failing grade.		
In-Class Participation (20%)	Actively participate in at least 13 classes.	
Online Discussion (40%)	Your online discussion grade is based on two components:	
	% of posts turned in on time	33%
	Successfully posting each response type.	66%
Final Exam (40%)	Your final exam grade is based on what level you reach	
	Level 1: Correctly identifying and describing each major ethical theory we cover. Stopping here earns you a 'C' on your final exam.	
	Level 2: Identifying practical obligations of each of the covered theories. Stopping here earns you a 'B' on your final exam.	
	Level 3: Explain how a theory we covered guides decision making for a case/topic we covered in class, and whether it is an appropriate application of that theory. Stopping here earns you a 'A' on your final exam.	
Advanced Assignments	Up to two Advanced Assignments may be used to improve your grade. The first will raise your overall grade by 1/3 of a letter grade, the second by an additional 2/3. See the course Canvas page for advanced assignment options.	

Course Requirement Details:

A. IN-CLASS PARTICIPATION:

This is a college-level ethics course. While many courses can be designed to provide alternatives to talking in class, this is not one of those courses. Students will be expected to contribute to in-class discussions. The discussions we have in class will: 1) prompt students to apply the concepts discussed in the previous classes, and 2) encourage them to remember what their fellow classmates said. **Full points on this criteria will be awarded to those who talk, in an engaged way, in at least 13 classes (ignoring workshop days).** Points will be reduced based on the number of classes with missed engagement out of the 13 required.

B. KEYWORD DISCUSSIONS:

Keyword discussions are an online exercise designed to develop your argumentative and analytical skills. Much of your engagement in the course will be here. There are two parts: (1) initiating the conversation by selecting “keywords” from the reading; (2) discussing these keywords online.

There are eight different possible roles one can uptake during a discussion (you must choose one for *every* post):

- ***Initiator***. Your job is to initiate a discussion. Propose 1-2 keywords (a word or short phrase) that capture focused, important features of the assigned text, along with concise (~100 words max) explanations of those keywords. Rule #1: Don’t be boring! Everyone’s done the reading so you don’t need to tell us the main thesis. Instead, highlight a narrow, focused aspect of the reading that you found interesting or memorable.
- ***Excavator***. Your job is to identify unstated premises or assumptions in either the assigned reading, keyword proposals, or other parts of the discussion. How does making those explicit enrich the discussion?
- ***Prospector***. Your job is to identify muted or understated consequences, entailments, or obligations of either the assigned reading, keyword proposals, or other parts of the discussion. How does identifying these consequences enrich the discussion?
- ***Contrarian***. Your job is to test the arguments, assertions, and premises of the keyword proposals, assigned reading, or other parts of the discussion. Consider whether you might defend an opposing thesis, or another position not yet considered. The spirit of this should be constructive, seeking to advance the discussion.
- ***Devil’s Advocate***. Your job is to advocate for a position with which you disagree, in order to understand that position better. Help keep us out of echo chambers and epistemic bubbles.
- ***‘Say More’***. Ask someone to expand on one of their points. Identify a post you’d like to learn more about, letting people know why you found this so insightful and are so curious to hear more.
- ***Dichotomy Skeptic***. Identify a binary stance or dichotomous framing that could be ‘troubled’. How does adding this complexity or nuance elevate the discussion, prompt a better analysis of the topic, or help uncover a previously unnoticed stance.
- ***Eagle Eye***. Your job is to step back and help people keep an eye on the big picture, preventing us from getting lost in the weeds. Help connect your classmates' posts, relating them back to larger issues or themes in the class or to the assigned reading. Important: Be respectful, constructive, and aim to advance the discussion.

Tips:

- *Don't merely report what we (all) read; tell us what you think.*
- *If you post a question—especially a rhetorical question—try to also answer it.*
- *If you want to post more than once and adopt a different role, you may. 1-2 paragraphs is fine for these posts. Don't overthink this (I've done that for you). The goal is to facilitate an interesting discussion. If you've got something interesting to say, just say it!*

Over the semester, you must successfully perform each role at least once. Initiator posts are due the *Friday prior to the week the reading has been assigned*. The first round of responses are due by *Monday morning—at 10am—during the week the reading has been assigned*. Any post submitted after that point will not count. By the end of the semester, you will need to have posted at least one *Initiator, Excavator, Prospector, Contrarian, Devil's Advocate, Say More, Dichotomy Skeptic*, and *Eagle Eye* post.

C. FINAL EXAM:

Your final exam is available to begin on the first day of class and is due at the conclusion of the designated final exam period. There are three 'levels.' As you advance through them, you will earn a higher grade on your final exam. Level 1 is correctly identifying the ethical theories we cover in class, with very short descriptions. Completing this earns you a 'C.' Level 2 is identifying practical obligations entailed by each of the theories we cover. Completing this level earns you a 'B' on your final exam. To earn an 'A' on the final exam you must complete Level 3. This is done either by connecting the moral theories we covered to a case/topic we go over in class. For more details on the requirements for completing each level please see the course Canvas page.

D. ADVANCED ASSIGNMENTS:

Successfully completing the **In-Class Participation, Keyword Discussion, and Final Exam** assignments will earn you a 'B' in the class. To earn a higher grade you must complete **Advanced Assignments**. There are many to choose from, e.g., *Create a Course Playlist; Diversify the Course; Write an AJOB-Style Commentary*, among other options. You may complete up to two. The first advanced assignment will increase your overall grade by 1/3. For example—from a 'B' to a 'B+'. The second advanced assignment will increase your overall grade by an additional 2/3. For example—from a 'B+' to an 'A'.

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Preliminary Course Schedule

Subject to change. All changes will be posted to Canvas.

Week 1: January 5-9

1. Jan 5th
 - a. Syllabus

2. Jan 7th
 - a. Chapters 1-2 of Mill's *Utilitarianism*
 - b. Gustafsson, J. E. (2022). Bentham's mugging. *Utilitas*, 34(4):386–39. (It's a fun, quick read.)

Week 2: January 12-16

1. Jan 12th
 - a. *The Good Will and the Categorical Imperative* Immanuel Kant
2. Jan 14th
 - a. Section of *Nicomachean Ethics* Aristotle

Week 3: January 19-23 (Monday Holiday)

1. Jan 19th
 - a. No class (Holiday)
2. Jan 21
 - a. Ethics of Care — Nel Noddings

Week 4: January 26-30

1. Jan 26th
 - a. *Animalism and the Lives of Human Animals* Paul Snowdon
 - b. Locke, J., (1694) "Of Identity and Diversity," *Essay Concerning Human Understanding*.
2. Jan 28th
 - a. Schechtman Narrative Identity

Week 5: February 2-6

1. Feb 2nd
 - a. Haidt, J., Koller, S., and Dias, M. (1993). "Affect, Culture, and Morality, or Is It Wrong to Eat Your Dog?" *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, Vol 65(4):613 - 628
 - b. Nagel, T., (1974) "What is it like to be a bat?" *Philosophical Review*
2. Feb 4th
 - a. *All Animals are Equal* Peter Singer
 - b. Shanks et al 2009

Week 6: February 9-13

1. Feb 9th
 - a. Card, R. F. (2007). Conscientious objection and emergency contraception. *The American Journal of Bioethics*, 7(6):8–14.

2. Feb 11th
 - a. Workshop day

Week 7: February 17-20 (Monday Holiday)

1. Feb 17th
 - a. King, M. L. (1963). Letter from Birmingham jail. *The Atlantic Monthly*, 212(2):78–88.
 - b. Wynia, M. K. (2022). Professional civil disobedience — medical-society responsibilities after Dobbs. *New England Journal of Medicine*, 387(11):959–961.
2. Feb 19th
 - a. Having a Life vs Being Alive — Kushner

Week 8: February 23-27

1. Feb 23rd
 - a. This 'point-counterpoint' exchange in: <https://journal.chestnet.org/>. (The papers are short! Read all four!)
 - i. DeCamp, M., Snyder Sulmasy, L., and Fins, J. J. (2022). POINT: Does Normothermic Regional Perfusion Violate the Ethical Principles Underlying Organ Procurement? Yes. *CHEST*, 162(2):288–290. doi: 10.1016/j.chest.2022.03.012.
 - ii. James, L., Parent, B., Moazami, N., and Smith, D. E. (2022). COUNTERPOINT: Does Normothermic Regional Perfusion Violate the Ethical Principles Underlying Organ Procurement? No.. *CHEST*, 162(2):290–292. doi: 10.1016/j.chest.2022.03.011.
 - iii. DeCamp, M., Fins, J. J., and Snyder Sulmasy, L. (2022). Rebuttal From Dr DeCamp et al. *CHEST*, 162(2):292–293. doi: 10.1016/j.chest.2022.03.014
 - iv. James, L., Parent, B., Moazami, N., and Smith, D. E. (2022). Rebuttal From Dr James et al. *CHEST*, 162(2):293–294. doi: 10.1016/j.chest.2022.03.013.
2. Feb 25th
 - a. Discussion Section

Week 9: March 2-6

1. March 2nd
 - a. Quill, T. E. (1991). Death and dignity. *New England Journal of Medicine*, 324(10):691–694. (A classic and very moving article!)
 - b. Quill, T. E., Dresser, R., and Brock, D. W. (1997). The rule of double effect -- a critique of its role in end-of-life decision making. *New England Journal of Medicine*, 337(24):1768–1771.

- c. Boudreau, J. D., Somerville, M. A., and Biller-Andorno, N. (2013). Physician-Assisted-Suicide. *New England Journal of Medicine*, 368(15):1450–1452.
- 2. March 4th
 - a. Discussion Section

Week 10: Spring Break—March 9 - 14

Week 11: March 16-20

- 1. March 16th
 - a. Liao, S.-y. and Carbonell, V. (2023). Materialized oppression in medical tools and technologies. *The American Journal of Bioethics*, 23(4):9–23. PMID: 35262465.
- 2. March 18th
 - a. Tekin, S. (2021). Is Big Data the New Stethoscope? Perils of Digital Phenotyping to Address Mental Illness. *Philosophy & Technology*, 34(3):447–461.

Week 12: March 23-27

- 1. March 23rd
 - a. Knox, B., Christoffersen, P., Leggitt, K., Woodruff, Z., and Haber, M. H. (2023). Justice, vulnerable populations, and the use of conversational AI in psychotherapy. *The American Journal of Bioethics*, 23(5):48–50. doi: 10.1080/15265161.2023.2191040.
- 2. March 25th
 - a. Discussion section

Week 13: March 30 - April 3

- 1. March 30th
 - a. Gillon, R. (2015). Defending the four principles approach as a good basis for good medical practice and therefore for good medical ethics. *Journal of Medical Ethics*, 41(1):111–116.
 - b. Huxtable, R. (2013). For and against the four principles of biomedical ethics. *Clinical Ethics*, 8(2-3):39–43
- 2. April 1st
 - a. Brandt 1978

Week 14: April 6-10

- 1. April 6th
 - a. *Washington 2018*, Contextualism as a Solution to Paternalism in Psychiatric Practice

2. April 8th

- a. *Leshner 1997*, Addiction is a Brain Disease, and It Matters
- b. *Pickard 2021*, Is addiction a brain disease? A plea for agnosticism and heterogeneity

Week 15: April 13-17

1. April 13th

- a. Hull, D. (1986). "On Human Nature," *PSA: Proceedings of the Biennial Meeting of the Philosophy of Science Association*, Vol. 2: 3 -13.
- b. Admunson, R. (2000). "Against Normal Function," *Stud. Hist. Phil. Biol. & Biomed. Sci.*, Vol 31(1): 33-53.

2. April 15th

- a. Prinz, J. (forthcoming). "Is Morality Innate?" *Moral Psychology*, Oxford University Press. ^Read at least the first 15 pages^

Week 16 (Final Week): April 20 - 22

- 1. TBD: Will depend on what the class is most interested in.

Grades Due: Monday, May 4th

C. Philosophy of Addiction

Course Description

This course is about addiction, formally termed “substance use disorder” (SUD). In learning about and discussing SUD, this course touches on selfhood, willpower, self-control, dependence, disease, normalcy, diagnostic practice, and clinical definitions. By examining the history of the substance use disorder, we will draw out what “-use disorder” means, and what, if any, effective features of the diagnostic criteria there are. In coming to understand SUD, we will cover both pathways to and remedies for addictive behavior. Throughout the semester, we will be elucidating what contributes to addictive behavior, and ask how common it is across individuals.

Grading

15%: Attendance and Participation

15%: Prospective Idea 1

15%: Prospective Idea 2

35%: Term Paper / Final Exam

20%: Weekly Assignments

Attendance and Participation

Show up on time and ready to engage. Students are allowed one free, unjustified, absence. Each absence after that will cost 1.5 percentage points from the final grade. Students will also be expected to contribute to in-class discussions. The discussions we have in class will: 1) prompt students to apply the concepts discussed in the previous classes, and 2) encourage them to remember what their fellow classmates said. **Full points on this criteria will be awarded to those who talk, in an engaged way, in at least 13 classes (ignoring workshop days).** Points will be reduced based on the number of classes with missed engagement out of the 13 required.

Weekly Assignments

Each week, students will be asked to respond to some aspect of the assigned reading. They will have a choice of how they respond (eg. for or against). Expected length: 100 - 150 words. These will serve as discussion points in class and due two hours before class at the beginning of the week.

Prospective Ideas

Students will be asked to undergo the beginning stages of writing a paper—twice. When submitting a “prospective idea” in its gradable form, it will not be a full paper, but rather the idea of a full paper in the form of a developed outline or really rough draft. The first prospective idea will mainly draw on one’s intuitive interests as she enters the class; it will be due by Week 5. The second prospective idea will draw more majorly on the material we cover in class, due on Week 10. It may be inspired by one’s first prospective idea, but students are encouraged to conjure new ideas as well.

Term Paper

The term paper is the main product of this class. The final paper must draw on one of the two P.Is., and be 3500 words maximum. While the students are expected to present their term papers, they will not be graded on this presentation further than the “participation” grade.

Students will have the option of taking a final exam, rather than submitting a final paper. The exam will consist of written responses to concept identification questions and essay prompts. If students fail to submit at least one prospective idea, they default to taking the final exam.

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Course Calendar

Please note that the schedule is subject to change as the semester progresses; all changes will be announced through Canvas.

Fall 3350 Schedule

All readings can be found on Canvas

Module 1: Self Control

Week 1: Introduction

- *August 20th*
 - Read:
 - Syllabus
- *August 22nd*
 - Read
 - *Amaya 2020*, The Science of Self Control

Week 2: Breaking Down Self Control

- *August 27th*
 - Read:
 - *Herdova 2017*, Self-control and mechanisms of behavior: Why self-control is not a natural mental kind
- *August 29th*

- Optional:
 - *Sripada 2020*, The Atoms of Self Control

Explain: Prospectus 1 Assignment

Week 3: Self Control, Broken

- *September 3rd*
 - Read:
 - *Allom et al 2016*, Self-report and behavioural approaches to the measurement of self-control: Are we assessing the same construct?
- *September 5th*
 - Read:
 - *Saunders et al. 2018*, Reported Self-control is not Meaningfully Associated with Inhibition-related Executive Function: A Bayesian Analysis

Week 4: Self-Control, Still Broken

- *September 10th*
 - Read:
 - *Brownstein 2018*, Self-Control and Overcontrol: Conceptual, Ethical, and Ideological Issues in Positive Psychology
- *September 12th*
 - Read:
 - *Schwitzgebel 2008*, The Unreliability of Naive Introspection

Week 5: Effort: an epic tale

- *September 17th*
 - Read:
 - *Friese et al. 2019*, Is Ego Depletion Real? An Analysis of Arguments
- *September 19th*
 - Read:
 - *Inzlicht et al. 2018*, The Effort Paradox: Effort Is Both Costly and Valued

Week 6: Commitment Devices

- *September 24th*
 - *Bryan et al. 2020*, Commitment Devices
- *September 26th*
 - Group work day

Prospectus 1 is due by 11:59pm, Sunday, September 29th.

Module 2: Disease

Week 7: Addiction is a Disease

- *October 1st*
 - Read:
 - *Leshner 1997, Addiction is a Brain Disease, and It Matters*
- *October 3rd*
 - Read:
 - *Flanagan 2011, What is it Like to be an Addict?*

Week 8: FALL BREAK

Week 9: Or is it?

- *October 15th*
 - Read:
 - *Pickard 2021, Is addiction a brain disease? A plea for agnosticism and heterogeneity*
- *October 17th*
 - Read:
 - *Luhrmann et al 2015, Hearing Voices in Different Cultures: A Social Kindling Hypothesis*

Week 10: Case Studies

- *October 22nd*
 - Read:
 - *Bruce Alexander: The View from Rat Park (available online)*
- *October 24th*
 - Read
 - *Burroughs 1956, Letter from a Master Addict to Dangerous Drugs*

Week 11: Brief History of DSM Addiction Diagnosis

- *October 29th*
 - Read:
 - *Robinson and Adinoff 2016, The Classification of Substance Use Disorders: Historical, Contextual, and Conceptual Considerations*
- *October 31st: Happy Halloween!*
 - Reading:
 - *Norko and Fitch 2014, DSM-5 and Substance Use Disorders: Clinicolegal Implications*

Week 12: Addiction, Self-Control, and Evaluations

- *November 5th*
 - Read:
 - *Sripada 2021*, Impaired control in addiction involves cognitive distortions and unreliable self-control, not compulsive desires and overwhelmed self-control
 - Optional:
 - *Berkman et al 2017*, Self-Control as Value-Based Choice
- *November 7th*
 - Read:
 - *Pickard 2018*, The Puzzle of Addiction
 - Optional:
 - *Sripada 2018*, Addiction and Fallibility

Prospectus 2 is due by 11:59pm, Sunday, November 10th.

Module 3: Closing Out

Week 13:

- November 12th
 - TBD
- November 14th
 - TBD

Week 14: Workshop and Discussion

- November 19th
 - TBD
- November 21st
 - Paper writing workshop

Week 15: Presentations

- November 26th
 - *Paper presentations*
- November 28th
 - HOLIDAY BREAK

Week 16—Final week: Presentations

December 3rd - December 5th

- December 3rd
 - *Paper presentations*
- December 5th

- *Paper presentations*

Term Paper is due by 11:59pm, Sunday, December 8th.

Grades Due: Monday, December 23rd.